Stardust - Terra Deleta: Game Concept Document

Zoud GameLab Financial Literacy Jam · theme: Make FinLit Fun

1. Game Overview

The player-run economy of EVE Online meets the creativity of Minecraft: mine real ores, smelt them, design your own blueprints, and trade on a live market.

Stardust - Terra Deleta is a real-time space life sim and economy game. The inner planets of our solar system are gone; their remains circle the Sun as four rings of debris. Players live aboard the research starship WSC Alexander von Humboldt, parked beside a mysterious wormhole beyond Jupiter, and build a life and a career from what they find, learn, make and trade.

The story, in short. A wormhole opened near the far side of Jupiter. The research starship WSC Alexander von Humboldt went to study it and found, on the other side, a twin of our universe: a New Earth with air, water, forests and animals, but no humans and no sign that any had ever lived there. After a 12-month survey proved it could sustain human life, the ship came home through the wormhole to find our solar system devastated. Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars and most of their moons have been destroyed by something no one understands, and their remains circle the Sun as rings of debris. The crew rebuild, study, and look for answers, and the New Earth waits on the other side.

Inara. The lead character of the novel *Stardust - Inara*: an officer in the Starship's command centre, the Tower, and the one voice that talks the player through the whole game: launch clearances, finds, warnings, and the story as it unfolds. She likes fireflies, and keeps an old shirt that still smells of cedar, for someone she hopes to find again. Players hear her in 13 languages, including Arabic and Hindi.

The story before the game is the novel *Stardust - Inara*: it ends where the game begins. It is offered in the game in text and as an audiobook. A short illustrated, voiced slideshow tells the backstory before a new player's first launch.

- **Genre:** space life sim, mining and economy, with careers you learn through a shipboard library.
- **Platform:** mobile first (Godot 4; iOS and Android), then PC (Steam) and the web.
- **Audience:** a general audience of players who like exploration, crafting and economies; also anyone who wants to get better with money without being lectured.
- **What's different:** money is not a minigame here. It is the life of the ship. Every career, every trip and every build runs on choices about earning, saving, spending and borrowing, with real consequences that unfold in real time.

2. Core Gameplay

The loop: wake up in your quarters → study in the Starship Library to earn the skills you need → fly out to a debris ring → find a field with your scanner (a hiss, a rising tone, two bearings to lock it) → collect real-sized pieces of ore that must fit your hold → warp home and unload them with a receipt → sell on a live market, or save, invest and plan → smelt ore into metal and build approved designs at the Maintenance Deck → rest, because your body has limits.

- **Objectives:** build a career and a life: rise through a career's five bars (Pilot to Captain, Trader to CEO, and more), afford a better ship or a production plant, reach long-term goals.
- **The biggest decision comes first: your career.** What you choose to study decides your path.
- **Everyday challenges and decisions:** which ring and field to work; what fits your hold; sell now or wait for a better price; save, lock credits in a term deposit, or borrow; when the cargo hold is full, sell to make room or rent more space.
- **Players design what gets built.** Any player can draw up a blueprint in the drafting room (what it is, what it's made of, how it's built); the game's review team reads it and sends notes back to the player's COMMS at their desk. An approved design gets a serial number, can be built at the Maintenance Deck, and its copies are sold at auction.
- **Progression:** library books and five-question tests earn career bars (gold for a perfect score, silver otherwise; 4 of 5 correct to pass, and retakes any time); each bar takes more study than the last.
- **Uniforms:** every career a player studies has its uniform in their closet, its bars in gold or silver. They wear one at a time, and only the worn uniform's skill bonus counts, so they dress for the day's work. Gold bars give a slightly bigger bonus than silver, and each bar adds a little less than the one before. What the bonuses do:
  - **Mining:** collecting goes faster.
  - **Flight:** fuel lasts longer, and the scanner slowly reaches farther, so debris comes into view sooner.
  - **Engineering:** printing blueprint copies costs less.
  - **Science, fifth bar in gold:** the miner can choose which raw material to collect from a field, so when one runs short on the market and its price spikes, they can fill the hold with it.
- **Why it's fun:** a true-scale solar system, a scanner you play by ear, a Starship you dock with by autopilot, rare finds (one diamond in 100,000 is near-flawless), and Inara, the officer in the Tower who talks you through it in 13 languages, including Arabic and Hindi.

3. Financial Literacy Integration

Financial concepts are the game's systems, not quizzes bolted on:

Concept	How it plays
Earning and income	Every trip's ore is real income, sold on a live order book whose prices rise and fall.
Budgeting	Income against costs: time, rest, flight time, printing fees for blueprints, loan payments.
Saving and goals	Savings goals at the Starship Bank ("a new ship: 2,010 of 5,000") with progress bars.

Concept	How it plays
Interest earned	A savings account and 2, 4 and 8-week term deposits; closing a term early gives up the interest.
Borrowing and debt	The Bank weighs each loan (standing, income, debt, purpose) and shows the full cost before you sign.
Good debt vs bad debt	A loan for a bigger hold pays for itself; a loan spent on something used up today is gone tomorrow, and still costs more.
Paying off early	The payoff amount includes interest only to today, so paying early visibly saves credits.
Credit standing	On-time payments raise it (cheaper, bigger loans); late payments add fees and lower it.
Records	Every transfer gives a receipt with a code anyone can verify.
Renting vs owning	Extra cargo space costs 10,000 credits a week, paid up front: worth it only if the extra cargo earns more.
Fees and pricing	Printing blueprint copies has a setup fee and a per-copy cost; designers learn to price above their cost.
Risk and patience	Market prices move; selling everything at the bottom costs you.
Delayed gratification	Saving toward a named goal instead of spending now; a term deposit pays more for waiting.

Every career's library books also teach money in that field (a miner's uneven income, costing a build, budgeting a research project), so whichever path a player chooses, they learn to manage money in it.

What players should take away: money decisions compound over time; borrowing is a tool that must earn more than it costs; saving toward a named goal works; paying debt early saves money; spending for today has long-term costs.

4. Visual Style & Player Experience

- **Look:** realistic and clean: a true-scale solar system with NASA imagery of the Sun, Jupiter and Saturn, NASA's asteroid models for the debris, and a sleek research starship. Instruments are transparent, thin red outlines over the view, like a pilot's heads-up display.
- **Tone:** calm, curious and hopeful: rebuilding after loss, learning, and making a life far from home.
- **Interface and accessibility:** big touch controls for one thumb on a phone; sound cues backed by visual ones (the scanner bar, the gold rim cue, on-screen messages alongside what Inara says); the app in 13 languages, with Arabic laid out right to left; Inara's voice in 13 languages including Arabic and Hindi, or none.
- **Inclusive by design:** players choose a name from the game's list and a rank they earn, no real names; no player chat (a safe, quiet universe); suitable for a general audience.

5. Development & Future Plans

What ships for the jam: the game on phones and on PC. Sign-in; Private Quarters (bed, desk with the ledger, closet, bookshelf, filing cabinet); the Starship Library with books and five-question tests for **all five bars of every career**, wired to the career ladders, so a player can rise from Trainee to the top of their field; each bar, gold for a perfect record or silver, earns that career's uniform in the closet, and the uniform a player chooses to wear gives its career's skill bonus, with added in-game benefits; the 3D Starship and docking bay; the true-scale solar system, warp, radar and fuel; debris fields, scanner, collecting and unloading; the live market and blueprint auctions; the Starship Bank with savings, term deposits, loans and savings goals; flight time paid to the WSC; renting extra cargo space; the Maintenance Deck, where ore is smelted into metal and approved designs are built; the drafting room, blueprint review and COMMS at the desk; resting in bed or in the cockpit; Inara in 13 languages; the illustrated, voiced intro (also in Arabic and Hindi).

Languages at the jam. The app, its menus and Inara's lines are in 13 languages. **The library books and their tests are in English for the jam**: 191 of them (the Library subjects and the first career books) are already in Arabic, and the rest of the books in Arabic and the other languages are a planned upgrade after the jam.

A future companion game: Stardust - Terra Nova. The colonisation of the New Earth on the other side of the wormhole, on the ground. It shares the same WSC Bank and market, so resources gathered in space are sold to players on the planet's surface. Terra Nova is an MMO: players build communities to share resources and protect each other, because the New Earth's creatures have never seen our kind, and meeting them can be deadly.

Risks and how we handle them: content volume (hundreds of library books: written in batches and fact-checked); balance of the economy (every number is a live setting tuned in playtesting); accuracy of money lessons (checked against established financial-education sources).

6. Your Team

Eric Wagoner, founder and developer, Rise Solutions LLC. Game design, story, direction and every final decision. This is Eric's first game jam.

AI collaborators. Eric builds with AI models as his development team: Anthropic's Claude models do about 95% of the work (code, the game server, the library books and their tests, documents), and xAI's Grok about 5%. Every rule, story line and design decision is Eric's; the models write and check to his rules, and he reviews what ships.